er. In that sense, Batra's ability to nurture his distinct voice feels even more risky when you consider that he makes mainstream movies for Dharma Productions, a production house that has greatly relied on selling saccharine romances and family sagas for decades.

In the past two decades, Batra has tried his hand at every storytelling format he found at his disposal. Whether it is 'Genius of the Year', the viral *All India Bakchod* parody, starring Alia Bhatt and her IQ skills, or the 30-second ads he shot for brands like MakeMyTrip and Google. Last year, Batra even dabbled in non-fiction storytelling. After his widely anticipated Osho biopic was shelved in 2019, Batra moved on to creating and executive producing *Searching for Sheela* (2020), the bland Netflix documentary on the cult leader's secretary. Although no one is credited for directing *Searching for Sheela*, the task of finishing the project eventually landed in Batra's lap. It instilled in him a deep fascination for the medium. "It's limiting because as a storyteller you have to manoeuvre your story around the footage you have. But it's also open in the sense that you decide the spine of the story."

As a director, Batra is meticulous and fond of control. He likes improvising on set the same way he likes planning everything that is going to happen there. As Batra found out with *Searching for Sheela*, non-fiction poses more surprises. But to his own surprise, he found himself enjoying the uncertainty. "I liked the fact that the story tells you in which direction it is going," adds Batra. "I don't think *Searching for Sheela* landed the way I would have ideally wanted it to, but the learning has been so immense that I really want to venture into non-fiction storytelling one more time." ■

–Poulomi Das

CHANGING THE SCRIPT

In 2021, National Award-winning filmmaker **Nagraj Manjule** *was slated to make his widely anticipated Hindi debut with* Jhund*, the sports drama headlined by Amitabh Bachchan. But with theatres being shut due to the brutal second wave of the pandemic,* Jhund *didn't end up releasing last year. In 2022, Manjule quietly flips the script with* Vaikunth*, his 25-minute short in* Unpaused: Naya Safar*, Amazon Prime Video's lockdown anthology. Not only does* Vaikunth*–easily the most accomplished film of the lot–now mark the Marathi filmmaker's Hindi acting and directing debut, it also paints a haunting portrait of Covid mass cremations.*

Q. You've co-written, directed, and acted in *Vaikunth*. Looking back, what was the most challenging part of pulling the film off?

I'm more comfortable when I'm directing. When I'm acting, I feel pressured. It's more fear-based. Because as an actor, if I don't get it right, I'm also letting myself down. The worst part is that I don't exactly know how much I've succeeded in getting inside the character's mind. I relied on the responses of my collaborators on set more than my instincts. If they didn't like a take, I would do the scene again.

Q. Are you the kind of director who knows exactly what needs to be done once you are on set?

I'm not the kind of director who is averse to improvisation on set. Still, the outline of my script never changes–what alters is how an actor chooses to interpret the emotions. I think that's important because when you write a character, you are sitting alone in your room and creating them in your mind. It's when you cast an actor that your character comes to life, so it's necessary that I remain open to that input as long as the interpretation doesn't differ too much.

Q. For a film that essentially measures the severity of Covid death tolls, how did you go about capturing the sound of grief?

There is minimal dialogue in *Vaikunth*. I feel the tone of any film isn't just set by its dialogue. There are things only sound can convey. *Vaikunth* is set in a crematorium overflowing with dead bodies. So, the screams, wails and tears of the bereaved succinctly capture the atmosphere better than any conversation can.



MANDAR DEODHAR

Q. Your only co-actor in this film is a child. Is there a framework you follow when directing a child?

The idea is to not tell the child actor what to do but to try to get something out of them. I prefer explaining the emotions scene by scene. I don't believe in disclosing the script to them because understanding the script is not their job at all. Kids tend to get scared in front of a camera. As a director, it's important to give them confidence. ■

–with Poulomi Das